Parshas Noach

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The Lamplighter

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Parsha Insights

Noah Gets Flooded with Criticism

By Rabbi Elisha Greenbaum

I subscribe to a number of weekly e-Torah columns authored by rabbis and writers from around the world. Every single year, as I check out the offerings for the section of Noah and the flood, I wonder what exactly Noah did to justify so much criticism.

The Torah records that Noah was a righteous man, and then adds, almost as a throwaway line, "for his times." Faint praise it may be, and the commentators may well try to justify this thinly disguised put-down; however, it is astonishing how much scholarship has been devoted throughout the ages to explicate in agonizing detail the character flaws which might explain the less than fulsome description of Noah's righteousness.

Some sages explain that Noah deserved censure because he was preoccupied with saving himself and family, with the result that he ignored the needs of others. A subtly different reason given is that, convinced of the hopelessness of the situation, Noah neglected to pray for the salvation of the rest of the world. Another possible explanation concentrates on his lack of faith, while other commentators advance ever-darker descriptions of his perceived inadequacies.



It is surprising that we should go out of our way to highlight anyone's failings, let alone as complicated a character as Noah. Try to imagine the stresses he would have been subjected to on a daily basis: Noah was the lonely man of faith living in a depraved world, full of wickedness. He devoted a good chunk of his life to single-handedly building an ark on G-d's command, all the while suffering threats and humiliation from onlookers. He was the first conservationist, directly responsible for the propagation of plant and animal life after the flood, and had the strength and confidence to pick up the tangled remnants of existence and start rebuilding the world all over again at a relatively advanced age.

And yet, and yet... Noah may well have spent every waking moment of a long and honorable life devoted to G-d, and yet the Torah still records that more could have been done. There is a subtle but crucial distinction between dedicating oneself to G-d's tasks, and dedicating oneself to G-d.

The fifth Chabad-Lubavitch Rebbe, Rabbi Sholom Dov Ber, once attended a conference of rabbis which had been convened by the Russian government in their effort to ram through massive changes to the traditional Jewish educational system. At the risk of their lives and liberty, the rabbis worked passionately and collectively to protect our common heritage.

After the meetings broke up, Rav Chaim of Brisk came to say farewell to the Rebbe and discovered him sitting in his hotel room, overcome with tears.

"Lubavitcher Rebbe," he exclaimed, "you needn't weep. You did absolutely everything within your power!"

"Maybe so. But after all that, we did not succeed in foiling their plans."

If you view yourself as an employee of G-d with a job to do, as long as you put in the maximum effort while acquitting yourself honorably and responsibly, then, even if you fail, you can still sleep calmly at night.

However if one is less concerned with one's personal scorecard and instead focuses purely on G-d's purposes and desires, then one can never surrender nor relax, no matter the difficulties that challenge.

When Noah assessed the situation and recognized that his prayers would not improve the situation, did that acceptance excuse him from trying again and again? Certainly no blame can be directed at Noah for the fact that he alone was saved, but we must never make peace with a system where the many are lost and the few are saved.

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What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

Candle Lighting Times

Greater Toronto Area

Light Candles	6:14 PM
Shabbos Ends	7:13 PM

Parsha in a Nutshell

Parshas Noach

The Parshah is named "Noach" (Noah) after the protagonist of its major event: The Great Flood. It is found in Genesis 6:9.

G-d instructs Noah—the only righteous man in a world consumed by violence and corruption—to build a large wooden teivah ("ark"), coated within and without with pitch. A great deluge, says G-d, will wipe out all life from the face of the earth; but the ark will float upon the water, sheltering Noah and his family, and two members (male and female) of each animal species (and 7 of the "pure" species).

Rain falls for 40 days and nights, and the waters churn for 150 days more before calming and beginning to recede. The ark settles on Mount Ararat, and Noah dispatches a raven, and then a series of doves, "to see if the waters were abated from the face of the earth." When the ground dries completely—exactly one solar year (365 days) after the onset of the Flood—G-d commands Noah to exit the teivah and repopulate the earth.

Noah builds an altar and offers sacrifices to G-d. G-d swears never again to destroy all of mankind because of their deeds, and sets the rainbow as a testimony of His new covenant with man. G-d also commands Noah regarding the sacredness of life: murder is deemed a capital offense, and while man is permitted to eat the meat of animals, he is forbidden to eat flesh or blood taken from a living animal.

Noah plants a vineyard and becomes drunk on its produce. Two of Noah's sons, Shem and Japheth, are blessed for covering up their father's nakedness, while his third son, Ham, is punished for taking advantage of his debasement.

The descendants of Noah remain a single people, with a single language and culture, for ten generations. Then they defy their Creator by building a great tower to symbolize their own invincibility; G-d confuses their language so that "one does not comprehend the tongue of the other," causing them to abandon their project and disperse across the face of the earth, splitting into seventy nations.

The Parshah of Noach concludes with a chronology of the ten generations from Noah to Abram (later Abraham), and the latter's journey from his birthplace of Ur Casdim to Charan, on the way to the land of Canaan.

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Who among us can honestly state that they've exhausted every option, explored every path on our life-long mission to save the world? And if the world stubbornly refuses to be changed, does that excuse me from continuing to try? Noah did the best he possibly could, under the circumstances, but the lesson the Torah would have us learn is that as long as another person is in physical or spiritual danger we must not accept the inevitability of fate and content ourselves with self-preservation, but must try and try again, risking life and soul, to help save the world.

Jewish Matters

This Week's Jewish Highlights!

Sunday, October 18 • 7 Cheshvan

During the Second Temple era (circa 230 BCE), 7 Cheshvan was the day the Jew living farthest from the Holy Temple, on the banks of the Euphrates River, a 15-day journey from Jerusalem, arrived home from the Sukkot pilgrimage. All Jews waited for this before beginning to pray for rain. 7 Cheshvan thus marked the return to everyday activities after the spirituality of festival-rich Tishrei.

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In the Land of Israel, prayers for rain (adding the words v'ten tal u'matar to the appropriate blessing of the Amidah) begin on 7 Cheshvan. Outside the Holy Land, the prayer for rain begins on the 60th day after the autumnal equinox, December 4th or 5th.

Thursday, October 22 • 11 Cheshvan

The matriarch Rachel died in childbirth on 11 Cheshvan 2208 (1553 BCE), while giving birth to her second son, Benjamin.

Rachel was born in Aram (Mesopotamia) around 1585 BCE. Her father, Laban, was the brother of Jacob's mother, Rebecca. Jacob came to Laban's home in 1576 BCE, fleeing the wrath of his brother Esau. He loved Rachel and worked seven years tending Laban's sheep in return for her hand in marriage. But Laban deceived him, and on the morning after the wedding Jacob discovered that he had married Rachel's elder sister, Leah. Laban agreed to give him Rachel as well in exchange for another seven years of labor.

Rachel was childless for many years, while her elder sister and rival bore six sons and a daughter. Finally, in 1562 BCE, she gave birth to Joseph. Nine years later, while Jacob and his family were on the road to his ancestral home in Hebron after a 22-year absence, she bore a second son but died in childbirth. Jacob buried her by the roadside in Bethlehem, where "Rachel weeps over her children, for they are gone [in exile]" (Jeremiah 31:14). Her tomb has served as a place of prayer for Jews for more than 35 centuries.

Food For Thought

Noah was a tzadik, a very great man. He saved the entire world. But he didn't approach Abraham's greatness.
When G-d told Noah to build an ark before the world would be destroyed, Noah built an ark.
But when G-d told Abraham He was about to destroy the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah—cities corrupt and evil to the core—Abraham argued. He said, "Perhaps there are righteous people there! Will the Judge of All the Earth not do justice?"
Where Noah donned a warm coat for himself and his family, Abraham built a warm fire for the entire world.
Because Abraham felt a sense of ownership for the world in which he lived. If there was something wrong, it needed to be changed. Even if it had been decreed by the will of G-d.

Please Share with us your thoughts on The Lamplighter!

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

You are your brother's keeper

Rabbi Moshe Weiss

My Story - with the - Rebbe



When I was fourteen, a growth was discovered at the base of my spine – an aneurismal bone cyst. Thank G-d, it was benign, but because it was in such a sensitive place, the doctors we consulted were very reluctant to risk performing a procedure to remove it. Medication and radiation therapy helped to subdue it, but eventually this cyst began to affect a nerve in my leg. I was in pain, I struggled to function, and soon I could only hobble around on crutches. The bottom line was that for nearly all of 1974, I was out of commission. Instead of studying Torah in yeshivah, I was in the hospital or in bed at my home in Los Angeles. I had been hoping to join some friends who had gone to study at the Lubavitch yeshivah on Ocean Parkway in Flatbush, New York, but it just wasn't possible.

As the baby of the family, I didn't fully realize just how concerned everybody around me was and how hard my parents were taking it all. Long-time supporters of Chabad activities in California, my parents had a very close relationship with the Rebbe and were in constant contact with him about my condition.

Towards the end of that year, we got some really bad news. My doctor felt that if the cyst wasn't removed completely – by a terribly invasive operation – it would start affecting other organs.

My mother came home from the doctor crying. "I'm going to New York," she told my father. "I'm going to the Rebbe."

In addition to seeing the Rebbe, she also wanted to meet with a doctor at New York's Memorial Hospital for the Treatment of Cancer and Allied Diseases, a world specialist by the name of Dr. Marcove.

My father managed to get her an appointment for an audience with the Rebbe, but although I went with her to see the doctor in New York, I decided not to join her for the audience. At fourteen years old, I already thought of myself as a full-fledged chasid, and I knew that chasidim would normally only have an audience once a year – and I had already been to the Rebbe with my father a few months prior.

But as soon as she came into the Rebbe's office, he asked her where I was; clearly, he had been expecting me. After explaining my reason for not coming, my mother began to cry as she spoke about my medical situation.

"First of all," the Rebbe told her, "you're going to walk your son to the chupah." (Years later, before I was actually about to get married, I think he even mentioned this to her: "I told you you're going to take him to the chupah!")

My parents had sent my medical records to the Rebbe, but he wasn't impressed with the prognosis I had received. "Are you going to see another doctor here?" he inquired.

"Yes," my mother answered. "Dr. Marcove in Memorial Hospital."

The Rebbe was satisfied with this: "They have very prominent specialists there; you have nothing to worry about." The sense he gave that everything would be fine was a blessing in its own right.

The appointment with Dr. Marcove did bring refreshing news. In contrast to the other doctor, who was actually his student, his opinion was that since the cyst wasn't spreading, there was no reason to be concerned. All I had to do was work on strengthening my leg, which had atrophied from disuse.

My parents were obviously happy to hear this, and I was itching to go off to the Ocean Parkway yeshivah. But first my mother put the question back to the Rebbe.

"The only way I would agree for him to come to New York is if he brings me a letter from the doctor saying that it's okay," the Rebbe answered, before explaining why sending me to this particular yeshivah might not be a good idea: "There are a lot of steps at Ocean Parkway."

This was true: The only way to get around the Ocean Parkway study hall and dormitory was by walking up and down some five flights of stairs. But what was remarkable – aside from the unusual way the Rebbe put himself into my parents' position when giving his advice – was that, as far as I know, the Rebbe had never been to the yeshivah.

"On the contrary," Dr. Markov replied when we expressed the concern about the stairs, "I want you to walk more. It will be good for you!"

He was quite a prestigious doctor, not a person you would typically have a long conversation with, but he agreed to sit down and write a letter, using my legal name: "Dear Rabbi Schneerson. My patient, Howard Weiss, is able to walk five flights of stairs. As a matter of fact, I prefer that he does."

Steps aside, though, I didn't acclimate well to Ocean Parkway. With the trauma of the previous year, my parents understood that they couldn't keep me at home anymore, and I was set on going there. But whether it was because of my newfound freedom, or the cold climate, or the New York chaos, I wasn't doing well; I was learning Torah, but not as seriously as I should have.

Before long, 1975 passed, and in the beginning of 1976, I found myself in my dormitory room, with a cold – which was really just an excuse to lay in bed and read. Suddenly the door opened, and my brother-in-law Rabbi Sholom Ber Levitin walked in. More than a decade older than me, Sholom Ber ran several Chabad institutions in Seattle and was a very busy man; he didn't normally have time to visit and chat.

He asked me what I was doing in bed, I told him about my cold, and he walked out. That evening my older brother Yona Mordechai, who was studying in the yeshivah in 770, also came by.

"What's this about having a cold?" he asked me. "We have to go learn Torah!"

Despite my protestations, he schlepped me down to the study hall. "I'm going to come every night," he pledged, "and we're going to have a little study session." For the next few weeks, he did just that.

But it was only years later that I learned what had actually happened. The night before coming into my room, Rabbi Levitin had entered the Rebbe's office for a private audience, intending to get the Rebbe's guidance on some important issues in Seattle. But before he began, the Rebbe turned to him and asked, "What's happening with your brother-in-law?"

At that moment, the question of how his wife's brother was doing in yeshivah was probably the furthest thing from Sholom Ber's mind.

"I want you to find out what's going on, and get back to me," the Rebbe told him. "And I want you to tell the older brother that he needs to pay more attention to his younger brother."

I finally understood why my brother-in-law and my brother had come running to Ocean Parkway.

In a way, I had grown accustomed to receiving such personal guidance from the Rebbe. And yet, when I heard how the Rebbe opened that audience – one with an important emissary, involved in major communal work – by inquiring about the wellbeing of a fifteen-year-old boy who was struggling in yeshivah, it had a profound impact on me. The thought sometimes crosses my mind: Had I known at the time that the Rebbe was paying such close attention to how I was spending my time in yeshivah, I would have been transformed.

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Rabbi Moshe Weiss serves as the director of Chabad of Sherman Oaks, California. He was interviewed in September 2011.

Will AI Take Over the World?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

Question:

I'm getting a bit freaked out by this AI revolution. It seems like it's going to take over everything. Surely the Torah has something to say about it. Could artificial intelligence bring about the end of the world?

Response:

The Torah has a much happier ending to the story of humanity. Not robots taking over the world, but rather the arrival of Moshiach, a time of peace, prosperity and spiritual enlightenment.

And yet, robots may play an important role in that time. The prophet Isaiah predicted, "Strangers shall stand and tend your flocks, and foreigners shall be your farmers and vineyard workers." Maybe those "foreigners" will turn out to be robots doing all the menial work while we get on with more important things.

But what if the robots don't agree to being servants? What if they develop a mind of their own, become difficult to control, and threaten to destroy everything?

Well, it's happened before. The Torah tells us all about it. That's pretty much what the book of Genesis is about. And we are the robots.

G-d created human beings, gave us intelligence and free choice, and look what happened. Adam and Eve disobeyed their very first instruction. Cain murdered his brother. Within ten generations, humanity had become so corrupt that the world needed a Flood. And not long after that, mankind united to build the Tower of Babel in an attempt to challenge heaven.

Sounds a bit familiar. A creator makes an intelligent being, gives it a degree of independence, and it rebels against its master.

The Torah doesn't just present the problem. It has solutions. Genesis offers three different responses to the misuse of intelligence and power.

The first is the Flood. When a creation becomes destructive beyond repair, sometimes you have to shut it down and start again. Not everything we are capable of creating should be allowed to continue.

The second is the Tower of Babel. When humanity united its powers for the wrong purpose, G-d divided them, confused their languages and scattered them across the earth. Sometimes the answer is not destruction but decentralisation. Don't allow too much power to be concentrated in one place.

The third is Abraham. This is the ideal. Rather than continually intervening to stop humanity from going wrong, G-d introduces us to a man who chooses to live according to a higher moral code, and who teaches that code to others. The ultimate solution is not to control intelligence from the outside, but to instil a moral compass that guides it from within.

These are three very relevant principles for the AI age. Know when to pull the plug. Don't concentrate unlimited power in one place. And above all, make sure our technological advances are guided by moral values.

The answers to our biggest questions, even in this robotic age, can still be found in a handwritten scroll given to us over three thousand years ago.

AI can do our laundry, and may even perform open-heart surgery one day. But it can't do morality for us. That is one responsibility we must never outsource.

Living Moshiach

"The rainbow will be seen in the cloud." (Noach 9:14)

The Zohar (I:72b) states that the rainbow is one of the signs of the future redemption.

Commentators note that the rainbow indicates the purification and refinement that the world underwent by means of the Flood. Before the Flood the clouds were very coarse, thus preventing a reflection of sunlight. Thereafter, however, the clouds became more refined; they reflected sunlight, thus bringing about a rainbow.

This, then, is the connection between the rainbow and the future redemption: The entire world will attain the peak of refinement with the coming of Moshiach.

Mitzvah Minute

"Be fruitful and multiply" is counted as the Torah's first mitzvah, and its purpose is to make the world a fitting dwelling place for G-d. The Torah obligation is met with one son and one daughter, though the sages added a duty to keep having children throughout life.

Women are exempt from the Biblical obligation, though many authorities say they have a rabbinic one. Most authorities say non-Jews are not obligated, but the Lubavitcher Rebbe taught that Jews should encourage them to keep the world inhabited.

The mitzvah also includes caring for one's children, and some say adopting an orphan fulfills it. Spiritually, it includes inspiring another Jew in Torah. It carries great moral weight, and the coming of Moshiach is tied especially to its merit.

The Lamplighter

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The Lamplighter is inspired by the works of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

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